

THE GREAT
DESIGN

Chopsticks



THE GREAT DESIGN

FIELD NOTES ON
ASIAN AMERICAN DESIGN

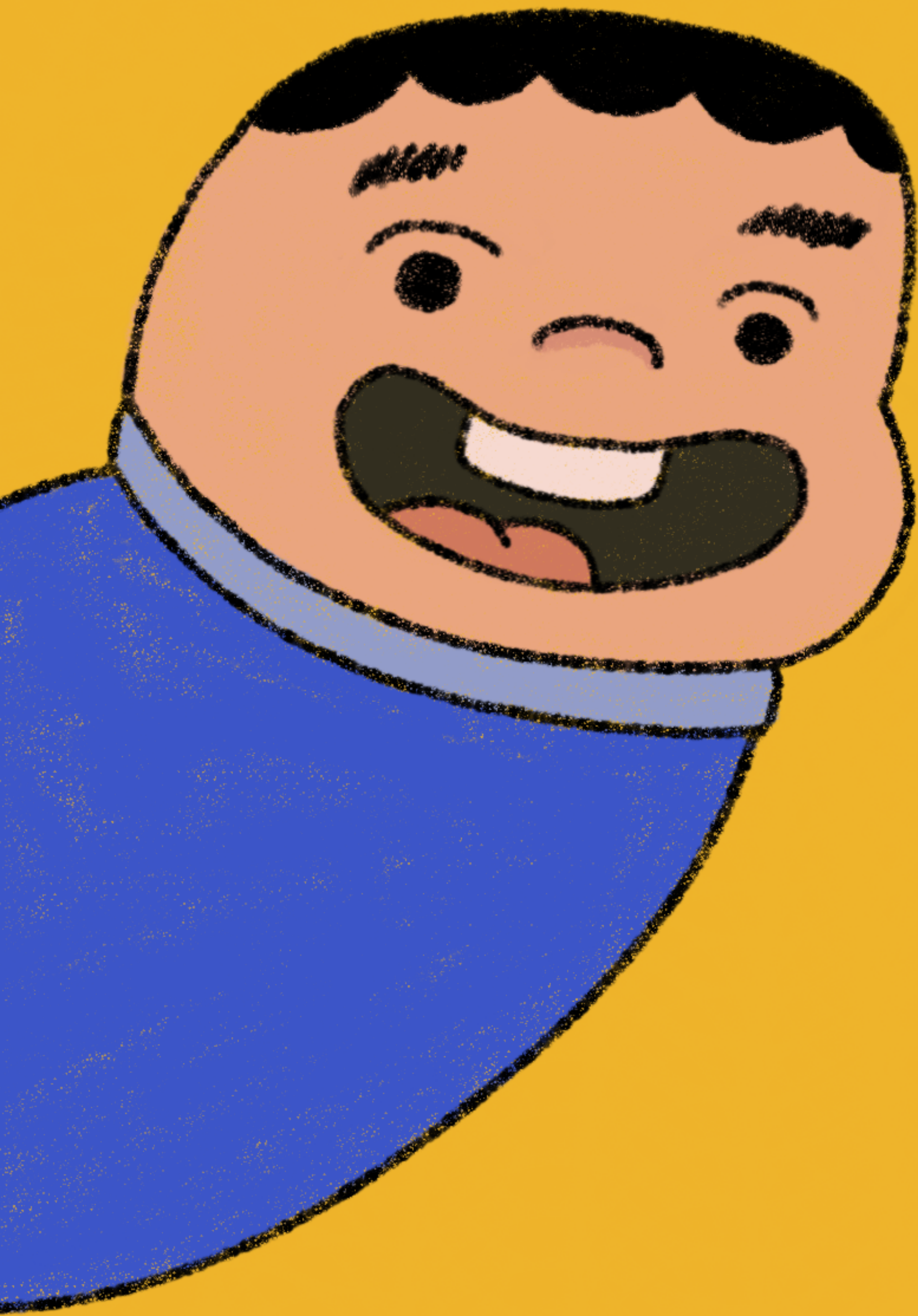


USED BY OVER A FIFTH OF THE
WORLD'S POPULATION,

CHOPSTICKS HAVE BEEN A
QUINTESSENTIAL TOOL SUPPLEMENTING
CHINESE, JAPANESE, AND
KOREAN CULINARY EXPERIENCES
FOR OVER 5000 YEARS.

WIELDED AS AN EXTENSION OF
THE HAND, CHOPSTICKS BEAR A
RICH AND ILLUSTRATIVE HISTORY.





THE EARLIEST KNOWN RECORD
OF THE UTENSIL DATES BACK TO
THE SHANG DYNASTY (c. 1600 - 1046 BCE)
WHERE ARCHAEOLOGISTS UNCOVERED SIX
BRONZE STICKS IN THE SHANG CAPITAL
RUINS OF ANYANG, CHINA.

ORIGINALLY, CHOPSTICKS
SERVED A DUAL PURPOSE AS BOTH
A COOKING AND EATING UTENSIL.

IT WASN'T UNTIL THE
MING DYNASTY, WITH THE
INCREASE OF RICE
CONSUMPTION,



DID CHOPSTICKS
BECOME EXCLUSIVELY
USED FOR SERVING AND EATING.

OVER TIME, CHOPSTICKS
SPREAD THROUGHOUT EAST AND
SOUTHEAST ASIA, FORMING WHAT
SCHOLARS HAVE DESCRIBED AS A
"CHOPSTICKS CULTURAL SPHERE."





AS AN OVERARCHING
GENERALIZATION,
CHOPSTICKS TEND TO
BE A PAIR OF TWO
EQUALLY-SIZED STICKS.

HOWEVER, ACROSS
CULTURES AND REGIONS,
SUBTLE DIFFERENCES
DISTINGUISH ONE PAIR
FROM ANOTHER.

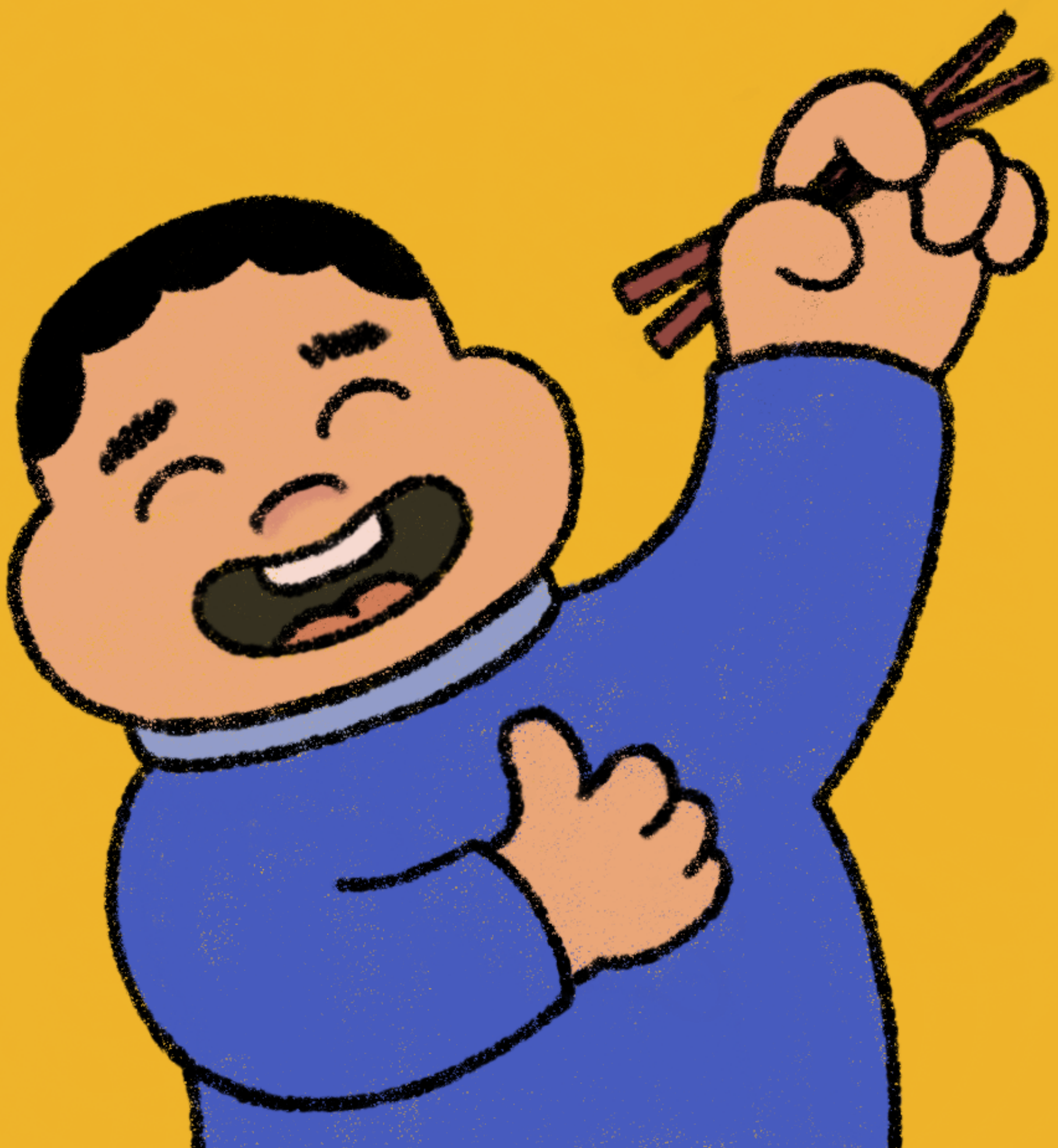
CHINESE CHOPSTICKS ARE MADE
LONGER AND THICKER THAN IN
OTHER ASIAN CULTURES.

A REASON FOR THEIR DESIGN
IS BECAUSE SHARING IS AT THE
HEART OF CHINESE CUISINE.
LONGER CHOPSTICKS ALLOW TO
REACH DISHES FARTHER.



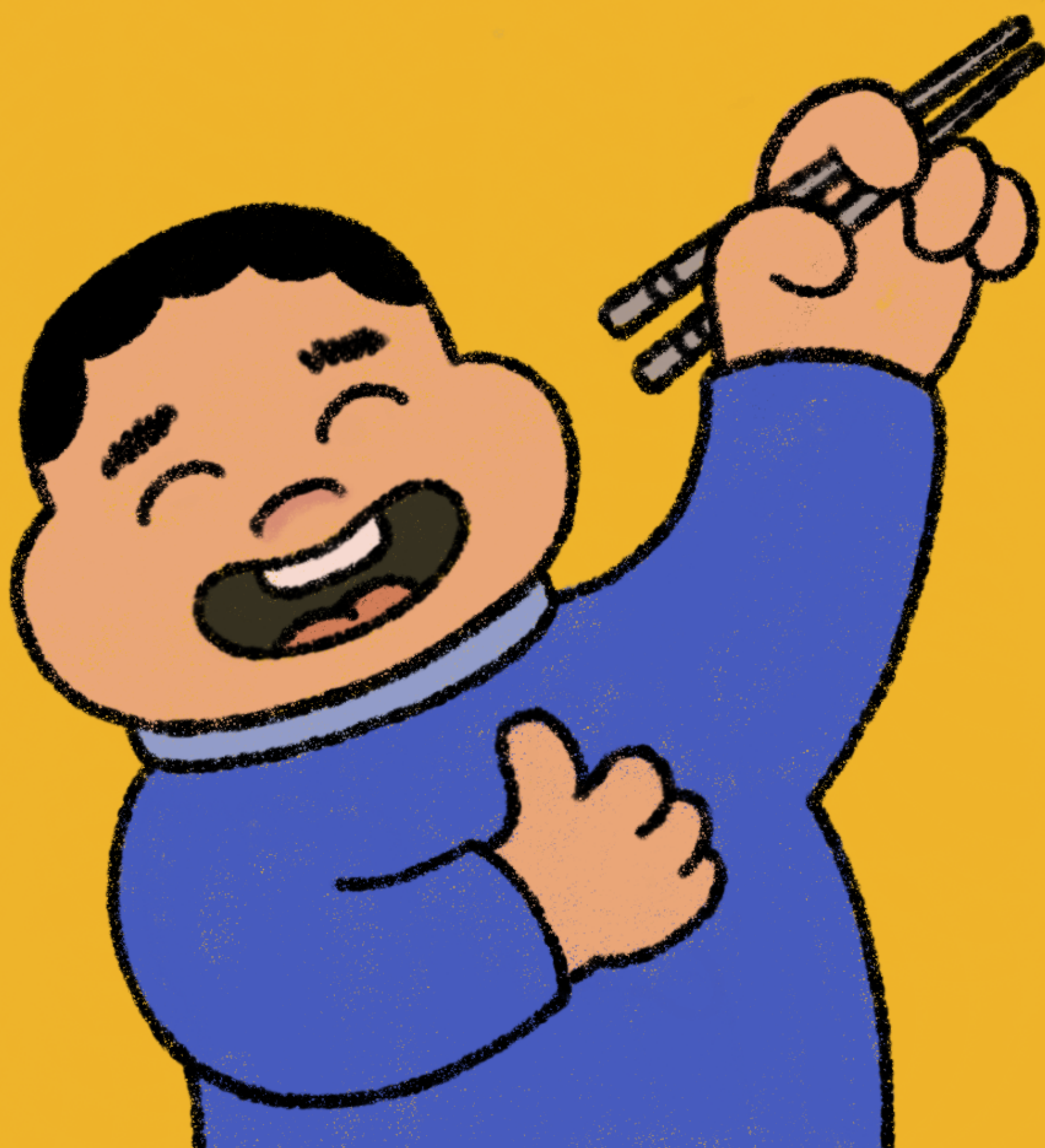
JAPANESE CHOPSTICKS TEND TO
BE SHORT AND TAPERED DOWN TO
A POINTED END, AS WELL AS HAVING
A LACQUER COATING.

BECAUSE FISH IS A STAPLE IN
JAPANESE DIET, THE POINTED ENDS
HELP TO EASILY PICK BONES
FROM MEAT.



KOREAN CHOPSTICKS ARE MADE
OF METAL SUCH AS BRASS OR
SILVER WITH A MEDIUM LENGTH.

IT WAS ONCE BELIEVED THAT SILVER
CHOPSTICKS COULD DETECT ARSENIC
POISONING. EVENTUALLY, METAL
CHOPSTICKS GREW IN POPULARITY
FOR THEIR DURABILITY AND LIGHTNESS.



HOLDING CHOPSTICKS
IS AN ART FORM.

HERE ARE SOME OF MY
FAVORITE HOLDS.

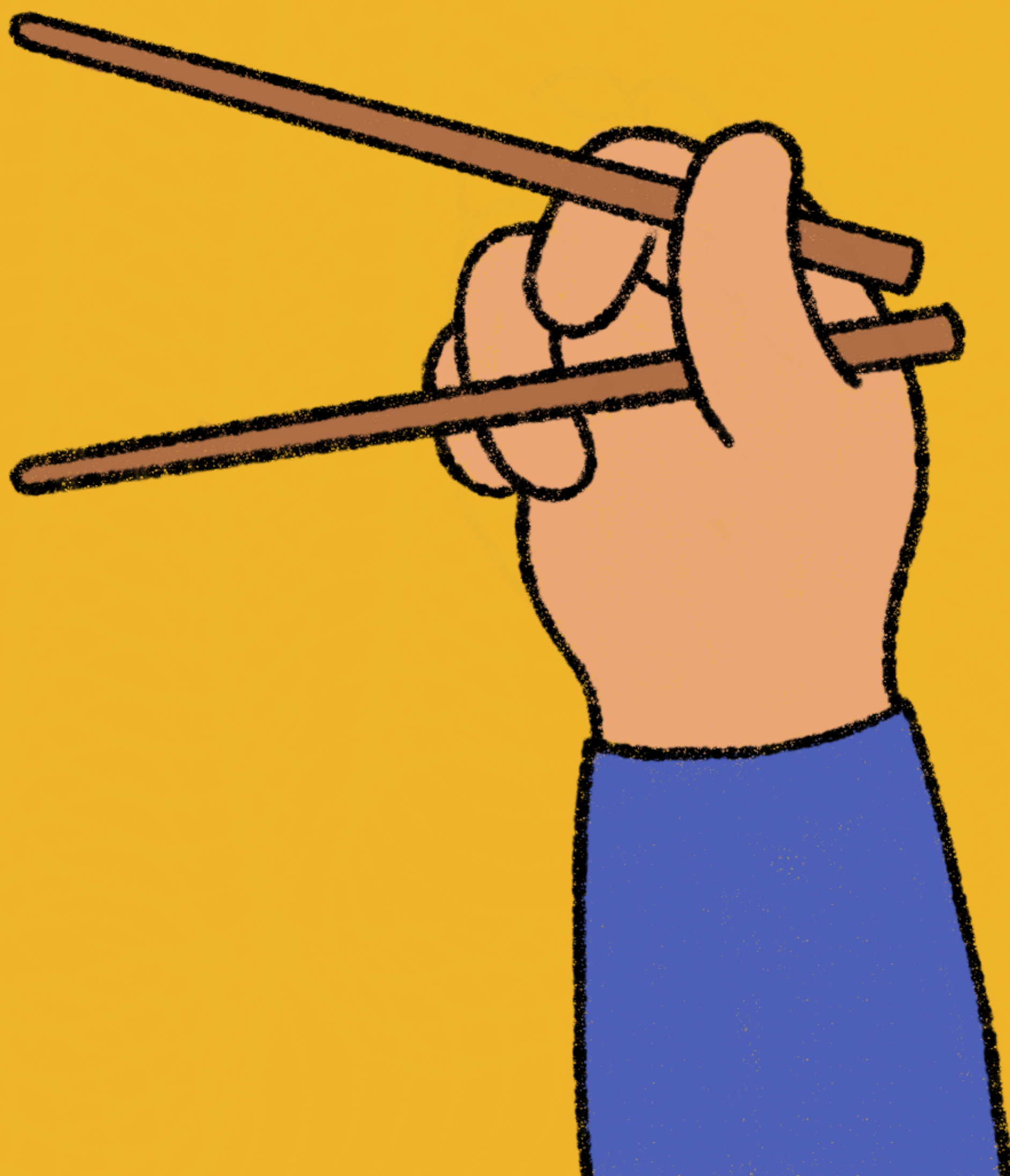
THE ITALIAN GRIP



THE MUPPET GRIP



THE CHICKEN CLAW GRIP



THAT'S IT!



CHOPSTICKS OUT!

